

Block 3 — Chapter 13: Mechanic Privileges & Limitations

Plain-English Study Guide — read this instead of slogging the chapter, still know everything

Block 3 — General | Built 2026-06-14 | Source of truth: assigned chapter PDF "*Chapter 13 Mechanic Privileges and Limitations*" (8 pp.), built on **14 CFR Part 65** — Subpart A (General), Subpart D (Mechanics), and the Inspection Authorization sections. | **This chapter is reg-number heavy — the section numbers and timeframes get tested COLD. Memorize them.** | SUMMARY ONLY (no quiz/flashcards yet, per your request).

0. The Big Picture (read this first)

What Part 65 is: Part 65 is the FAA rulebook for certifying **airmen who are NOT flight crew** — i.e., the people on the ground who keep airplanes legal and safe. ("Airman" here just means an FAA-certified person, not necessarily a pilot.) Part 65 has six subparts; this chapter only cares about **two of them: Subpart A = General rules** (apply to everybody) and **Subpart D = Mechanics** (the A&P rules), plus the **Inspection Authorization (IA)** sections. (p. 1)

Two kinds of maintenance technician — know the difference cold:

- **Mechanic certificate (the A&P) = transportable.** It belongs to YOU based on your training and knowledge, and it travels with you no matter where you work.
- **Repairman certificate = tied to one location/employer.** It is issued to you only while you work at a **specific company at a specific address**, and that address is printed on it. When you leave that job, you must **return the repairman certificate to the FSDO** (Flight Standards District Office) that issued it.

Analogy: A mechanic certificate is like a **driver's license** — it's yours, it works anywhere. A repairman certificate is like a **building access badge** — it only works at the one company that issued it, and you hand it back at the door when you quit. (p. 1)

1. Subpart A — General Rules (the §65.1x block)

These apply to **all** Part 65 airmen, not just mechanics. They are the "paperwork, honesty, and testing" rules. The full reference table is below; the high-yield numbers are spelled out underneath it.

14 CFR §	Title (plain meaning)
SUBPART A — GENERAL (applies to all Part 65 certificate holders) — ch. pp. 1–3	
65.3	Certification of foreign airmen. FAA normally issues these certificates only to U.S. citizens or resident aliens . Exception: it will issue to a person OUTSIDE the U.S. if needed for the operation/continued airworthiness of a U.S.-registered civil aircraft , if they meet the requirements.
65.11	

	Application & issue. Apply on FAA Form 8610-2 (Airman Certificate and/or Rating Application). If SUSPENDED , you may not apply for additional ratings during the suspension. If REVOKED , you may not apply for a certificate for 1 year after the revocation.
65.12	Offenses involving alcohol & drugs. A conviction for a drug offense (growing, processing, manufacturing, selling, disposing, possessing, transporting, or importing narcotics/marijuana/depressants/stimulants) can get your application denied for up to 1 year after the conviction date, and can cause suspension or revocation of a certificate you already hold.
65.13	Temporary certificate. Pass all required tests with at least 70% and you may get a temporary certificate good for not more than 120 days , while the FAA reviews your paperwork and issues the permanent one.
65.14	Security disqualification. Added after 9/11/2001 . If TSA determines you are a security threat , your application is held, or a certificate you hold is revoked .
65.15	Duration of certificates. A mechanic certificate is effective until surrendered, suspended, or revoked (no expiration date). Surrendered = you give it up voluntarily. Suspended = FAA temporarily removes it. Revoked = FAA permanently removes it.
65.16	Change of name / replacement of lost or destroyed certificate. A name change must include your current certificate plus a marriage license, court order, or other verifying document . Name-change and replacement requests go to the FAA Airmen Certification Branch (AFB-720), P.O. Box 25082, Oklahoma City, OK 73125 . There is a nominal charge .
65.17	Test: general procedure. Tests are given by FAA-designated persons. Minimum passing score = 70%.
65.18	Written tests: cheating / unauthorized conduct. If you cheat (copy/remove the test, give or receive any part of it or any help, take it for someone else, or use unauthorized aids), you are ineligible for any certificate or rating for 1 year , and current ratings may be suspended or revoked .
65.19	Retesting after failure. Two options: (1) wait 30 days from the failure date, then retest; OR (2) get additional instruction and bring a signed statement from the certificated technician who instructed you saying you're ready — then retest with no wait .
65.20	Falsification, reproduction, or alteration. Grounds to suspend or revoke any certificate/rating: a fraudulent or intentionally false statement on an application ; a fraudulent/false entry in any logbook, record, or report required for a certificate; reproducing a certificate for fraud; or altering a certificate. (Ties to part 43 §§43.9 & 43.11 record-entry rules.)
65.21	Change of address. Notify the FAA in writing within 30 days of a change of permanent residence (same Oklahoma City Airmen Certification Branch address).

Plain-words drill-down on the heavily-tested General sections

The three “states” of a certificate (§65.15) — the FAA loves to test these definitions:

- **SURRENDERED** = you gave it up **voluntarily**.
- **SUSPENDED** = FAA pulled it **temporarily** (you can get it back). After a suspension → you can't apply for added ratings *during* the suspension (§65.11).

- **REVOKED** = FAA pulled it **permanently**. After a revocation → you can't even apply again for **1 year** (§65.11).

The two retesting paths (§65.19): Think of it as “wait or weight.” Either **WAIT 30 days**, or add the **WEIGHT** of a signed instructor statement and retest immediately. Those are the only two paths.

(p. 2)

Bonus topic the chapter folds in here (drug/alcohol testing — part 120, not part 65): Refusing a required drug/alcohol test (under **14 CFR part 120**) can get your application denied and existing certificates suspended/revoked. **§120.117** (drug program) requires a **urine sample**; **§120.37** (misuse of alcohol) requires a **breath test**. Memorize the **seven times testing can be required**: (1) **pre-employment**, (2) **periodic**, (3) **random**, (4) **post-accident**, (5) **reasonable cause**, (6) **return-to-duty**, (7) **follow-up**. (pp. 2–3)

2. Subpart D — Mechanics (the §65.7x & §65.8x block)

This is the heart of the chapter — the rules for **becoming** an A&P and what an A&P **may and may not do**.

14 CFR §	Title (plain meaning)
SUBPART D — MECHANICS (the A&P rules) — ch. pp. 3–5	
65.71	Eligibility (general). Must be 18+ years old ; read/write/speak/understand English ; have passed all required tests within the preceding 24 months ; and possess/demonstrate the right knowledge & skill for the rating sought.
65.73	Ratings. Two ratings: Airframe and Powerplant . Can be earned separately or as a combined A&P. Old A or E certificates valid before June 15, 1952 can be exchanged for the current equivalents (A & E → A&P).
65.75	Knowledge (written) requirements. Pass written test(s) at 70% (§65.17). Three tests: General = 60 questions, Airframe = 100, Powerplant = 100. Includes applicable parts of 14 CFR 43 & 91 ; propeller install/maintenance basics are in the Powerplant test. Must pass written BEFORE applying for the oral & practical (§65.79).
65.77	Experience requirements. Either a certificate of completion from a part 147 certificated AMTS (your AIM school), OR documented practical experience: 18 months for ONE rating (airframe OR powerplant), 30 months for BOTH.
65.79	Skill (oral & practical) requirements. Take the oral and practical tests AFTER passing the written . Powerplant practical also requires demonstrating minor repairs & minor alterations to propellers . Standards are in the Aviation Mechanic Practical Test Standards (PTS) .
65.80	Certificated AMTS students. A part 147 school student making satisfactory progress may take the oral & practical (§65.79) BEFORE finishing the curriculum and BEFORE taking the written (§65.75).
65.81	General privileges & limitations. See the “may / may NOT” box below — this one is tested hard.
65.83	Recent experience requirements. Can't exercise the certificate unless you've been actively working as a mechanic at least 6 of the preceding 24 months (see box below).
65.85	

	Airframe rating — additional privileges. May approve & return to service the airframe/appliance/part after minor repairs/alterations, and may do the work for a major repair/alteration (start FAA Form 337) — but the return to service for a major must be signed by an IA (§65.95). May do the airframe 100-hour inspection (per part 91 §91.409). Light-sport exception noted below.
65.87	Powerplant rating — additional privileges. Same deal for powerplant & propeller: return to service minor repairs/alterations; do the work for a major but the return to service must be signed by an IA ; may do the 100-hour inspection on a powerplant/propeller. Light-sport exception noted below.
65.89	Display of certificate. Keep the certificate in the immediate area where you normally work, and present it on request to the FAA, NTSB, or any federal/state/local law-enforcement officer.

§65.71 — Eligibility, spelled out (memorize the four)

To get a mechanic certificate you must:

1. Be at least **18 years old**.
2. **Read, write, speak, and understand English.** (If you can't and you work outside the U.S. for a U.S. carrier, the cert is endorsed "**valid only outside the United States.**")
3. Have **passed all required tests (written, oral, practical) within the preceding 24 months.**
4. **Possess and demonstrate** the appropriate knowledge and skill for the rating.

Adding the second rating later? Same deal — meet §65.77 experience and take written+oral+practical **within 24 months**. Memory hook: "**18 / English / 24 months / know-and-show.**" (p. 3)

§65.81 — General Privileges & Limitations (the “may / may NOT” rule)

An A&P **MAY**: perform or supervise the maintenance, preventive maintenance, or alterations of an aircraft or appliance (or part) **for which they are rated**. The mechanic must **have and understand the maintenance manuals / instructions for continued airworthiness** for the task.

An A&P may **NOT**:

- Do a **major repair or major alteration to a PROPELLER.**
- Do **ANY repair to, or alteration of, INSTRUMENTS.** (Props-major and instruments are reserved for **certificated repairmen at an authorized repair station.**)
- **Supervise** a task **unless they have satisfactorily performed that same work at an earlier date.**

Why the OJT log matters: Because of that last rule, you can only **supervise** work you've already **done yourself** and logged. That's why keeping an **On-the-Job-Training (OJT) log** is huge — it's

your proof. **Memory hook for the two big NO's: "No major PROP, no INSTRUMENTS"** — PI (Props/Instruments) are off-limits. (p. 4)

§65.83 — Recent Experience (the "6 of 24" rule)

Your A&P never **expires** (§65.15) — but you can't **USE** it unless you've been active as a mechanic for **at least 6 of the preceding 24 months**. "Active" counts if you did **any one (or a mix)** of:

- Served as a **mechanic** under the certificate and rating;
- **Technically supervised** other mechanics;
- **Supervised, in an executive capacity**, the maintenance or alteration of an aircraft.

Memory hook: "6 of 24 keeps it alive." Don't confuse the certificate **existing** (forever, until surrendered/suspended/revoked) with the certificate being **exercisable** (only if 6-of-24 is met). The FAA loves that trap. (p. 4)

§65.85 / §65.87 light-sport exception (know it exists): An airframe (or powerplant) mechanic **can** approve & return to service a **major** repair/alteration on a **special airworthiness certificate light-sport aircraft** (per part 21 §21.190) **without an IA** — but only on products **not produced under FAA approval (not type certificated)** and done per manufacturer (or FAA-acceptable) instructions. For normal type-certificated aircraft, a **major** still needs IA sign-off. (p. 4)

3. Inspection Authorization — IA (the §65.9x block)

The IA is the **next step up** from A&P. It lets you **approve major repairs/alterations for return to service** and perform **annual inspections** — things a plain A&P can't finish alone. These four sections are **heavily tested**.

14 CFR §	Title (plain meaning)
INSPECTION AUTHORIZATION (IA) — ch. pp. 5–6	
65.91	IA — eligibility. Hold an A&P for at least 3 years, active the last 2 years ; apply on FAA Form 8610-1 ; have a fixed base of operation + equipment, facilities, and inspection data ; then pass a written test at 70% . Fail → wait 90 days to retest (no reduction for extra training).
65.92	IA — duration. Expires March 31 of each ODD-numbered year ; only usable while you hold a current mechanic certificate. Ceases if surrendered/suspended/revoked, OR you lose your fixed base, OR you lose your facilities/equipment/inspection data.
65.93	IA — renewal. Each year, renew by meeting any one of the activity options below (see box). Held the IA <90 days → no renewal required that cycle.
65.95	IA — privileges & limitations. May do an annual inspection; perform/supervise a progressive inspection; and approve for return to service after a major repair or alteration — EXCEPT aircraft on a continuous-airworthiness program under part 121 . Keep certificate available for: aircraft owner, A&P, FAA, NTSB, or any law-enforcement officer. If you move your fixed base , notify the new FSDO in writing BEFORE exercising IA privileges there.

§65.91 — Getting the IA, spelled out

The “3 and 2” rule: hold the A&P **3 years**, and be **active the last 2 years**. Plus: a **fixed base of operation** (a place you can be reached in person or by phone during a normal work week — it does NOT have to be where you actually do inspections); the **equipment, facilities, and inspection data** to properly inspect; apply on **Form 8610-1**; then **pass the written at 70%**. **Fail = 90-day wait** before retesting, and (unlike the A&P test) **extra training does NOT shorten the wait**. (p. 5)

§65.93 — Renewing the IA

Each year, do **ANY ONE** of these (you cannot **mix** them):

- **One annual inspection per 90 days** you’ve held the IA (so **4 annuals** over the year);
- **Two major repair/alteration inspections per 90 days** (so **8 over the year** — count whether approved or disapproved);
- Perform/supervise & approve **one progressive inspection**;
- Complete a **refresher course of at least 8 hours** acceptable to the Administrator;
- Pass an **oral test** by an FAA inspector (the “last resort” method).

The **cumulative trick the chapter calls out**: the **4 annuals / 8 major-inspections** are **cumulative by March 31**, not required in each individual 90-day chunk. You could go 11 months doing nothing, then do all 4 annuals (or all 8 337-inspections) in March. But you **cannot mix** methods (e.g., 2 annuals + 4 Form 337s does not count). (pp. 5–6)

⚠ **MUST KNOW — memorize these numbers & facts COLD**

- **70%** = minimum passing score on every test (§65.13, §65.17, §65.75, §65.91).
- **120 days** = max validity of a **temporary certificate** (§65.13).
- **1 year** = denial window after a **drug conviction** (§65.12), a **cheating** finding (§65.18), or a **revocation** before you can re-apply (§65.11).
- **30 days** = retest wait after a written failure (§65.19) *and* the window to report a **change of address** (§65.21).
- **18 years old + English + tests within 24 months** = A&P eligibility (§65.71).
- **Experience: 18 months** for ONE rating, **30 months** for BOTH (§65.77).
- **Written question counts**: General **60**, Airframe **100**, Powerplant **100** (§65.75).
- **§65.81 limits**: NO major repair/alteration to **PROPELLERS**; NO repair/alteration of **INSTRUMENTS**; can’t supervise work you haven’t done before.
- **§65.83**: active **6 of the preceding 24 months** to **exercise** the certificate (cert itself never expires — §65.15).
- **IA eligibility (§65.91)**: A&P **3 years**, active last **2 years**, Form **8610-1**, written at 70%; **fail** → **90-day wait**.

- **IA expires March 31 of each ODD-numbered year** (§65.92).
- **IA renewal (§65.93): 4 annuals OR 8 major-repair inspections OR 1 progressive OR 8-hr refresher OR oral test — cannot mix**; held <90 days = no renewal that cycle.
- **IA can't approve return to service on part 121 continuous-airworthiness aircraft** (§65.95).
- **Forms: 8610-2** = mechanic application (§65.11); **8610-1** = IA application (§65.91); **Form 337** = major repair & alteration.
- **Cert states:** Surrendered = voluntary; Suspended = temporary; Revoked = permanent (§65.15).

4. Ethics (the closing discussion)

What it is: “Ethics” comes from the Greek “**ethos**” (character / custom) and means “**the study of standards of conduct and moral judgment.**” For an A&P, ethics is doing the right, legal, airworthy thing even when the boss, the schedule, or the bottom line pushes you to cut corners. (p. 6)

The ice-shield scenario (the lesson): A tech removed a damaged fuselage ice shield believing a replacement was in stock; inventory was wrong. **Key rule:** once a damaged part is removed, it becomes **unairworthy and CANNOT be reinstalled** — even if it's deferrable on the **MEL (Minimum Equipment List)**. The inspector told him to reinstall it, then to do an unauthorized epoxy patch the shop wasn't authorized to make. The tech **refused and walked away**; someone else compromised standards and the aircraft **departed illegally and unairworthy**. Lesson: **it's the mechanic's responsibility to follow the regs and question a supervisor who circumvents them for an on-time departure.** (pp. 6–7)

The B.F. Goodrich brake scandal (the second example): A classic **whistle-blowing** case — a brake system that failed testing **14 times** was pushed toward qualification “no matter what,” under a culture of intimidation, leading to a **1969 congressional hearing**. Point: a **company culture of intimidation/distrust** transcends every industry, and **trust** is the foundation of long-term success. (pp. 7–8)

Two checklists worth remembering:

Seven-step ethical-decision checklist: (1) recognize/clarify the dilemma, (2) get all the facts, (3) list ALL options, (4) test each (Is it legal? Is it right? Is it beneficial?), (5) decide, (6) double-check (How would I feel if family knew? if it hit the newspaper?), (7) take action.

Four common ways people rationalize bad behavior: pretending it isn't unethical/illegal; claiming it's in the org's best interest; assuming no one will find out; expecting superiors to protect you (— they won't; in court they'll swear they always told you to work “by the book”). The chapter closes with the **PAMA Code of Ethics** — never approve work beyond your knowledge, and never let money or a superior push you to pass doubtful work as airworthy. (pp. 8)